

1800 – 1809

EMPIRE LINES

Fashion magazines produced hand-coloured plates for each month, specifying whether a dress was best for morning, afternoon, or eveningwear, or designed for a special occasion. In France the so-called Empire line had been fashionable since the 1790s (Napoleon became emperor in 1804). This simple style was inspired by classical Greek and Roman statuary, where figures were draped in fabric with minimal ornamentation. Waistlines were high and skirts had short trains until 1807 when straighter lines were favoured. The palette at this time was white or pastel shades, although trimmings and accessories could add brighter accents. Corseting was unboned but corded corsets separated the breasts and controlled waist and hips with back lacing. Dresses with short sleeves in simple cotton muslin required stoles and capes or pelisses to provide warmth. Some dresses were overlaid with layers of lace and gauze. Gradually, more exotic accessories became available, such as parasols and embroidered shawls from India.



Roman-toga style The influence of classical Roman dress is clear in this softly draped, white muslin dress. The light garment is covered by a cloak worn over one shoulder in the style of a Roman toga.



Grecian This style of dress clings to the body with draping reminiscent of a Grecian statue. The dress is simple with a trained skirt. A feather bonnet and boa lend elegance but very little warmth.

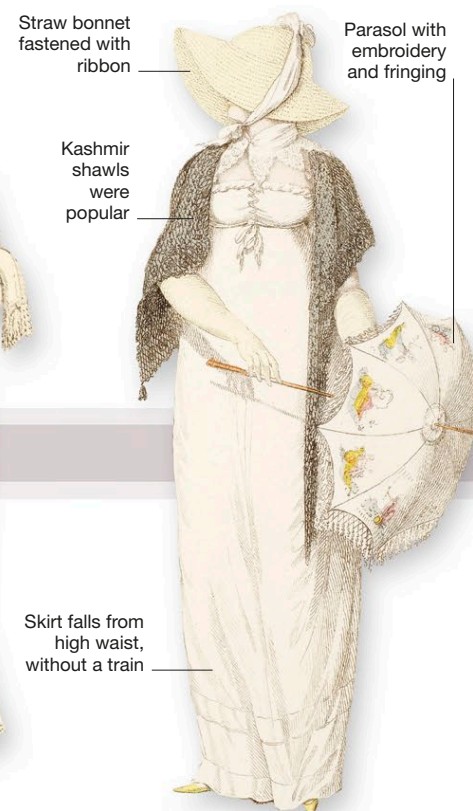


Classical influence Based on an idealized version of a classical Greek statue, this simple gown has very restrained decoration; just lace edging at the neckline and along the hem.



1800

Morning dress To keep warm on a winter's day, a feathered bonnet and lambswool muff could be worn with a neckerchief. The dress underneath has long sleeves and trailing skirts.



Cotton gown A light cotton gown cut in the high-waisted Empire line required little corsetry. The fabric was so thin and simple that decorative shawls were often worn for warmth and to add colour.